Major General Prabodh Chander Puri (retd) remembers the day clearly. It was October 15. The 83-year-old had been going about his usual routine when the phone rang in his house in Panchkula, Haryana. On the other end was a voice of authority—stern, direct and deeply unnerving. Claiming to be a senior official of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the caller informed Puri that his mobile number had come up in a financial scam investigation. To "protect his honour" and avoid immediate incarceration, he would have to submit to an interrogation. What followed was a chilling 48-hour ordeal. Puri was subjected to video calls that appeared to be from legitimate government offices. The scammers even created a horrifyingly convincing ruse: a courtroom simulation with actors playing judges, police officials and enforcement agents, complete with wireless static sounds and official-looking documents. Overwhelmed, Puri transferred Rs 82.27 lakh into multiple bank accounts in tranches. He was told the money was only a "refundable security deposit" to clear his name. By the time the truth dawned on him, the scammers had vanished, leaving Puri devastated and financially ruined.

Puri's is not an isolated account. He is one of a growing number of victims of a sinister new cyber con playing out across the country. Set up as an elaborate 'dark sting' operation, it casts its web around a wide array of people: retired officials, lawyers, bankers, doctors, professors, journalists and even tech-savvy professionals, forcing them to part with their entire life savings. Among the most high-profile was the case of S.P. Oswal, chairman of the Vardhman Group, India's largest textile conglomerate, this September. Cyber criminals staged an entire Supreme Court session over a video call, with actors brazenly posing as then Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud and senior investigators who alleged that Oswal's Aadhaar card had been misused in a major money-laundering scandal. For several days, he was held under a "digital arrest", forbidden to communicate with anyone else, even as the scammers intensified their demands. Oswal ended up transferring Rs 7 crore to what he believed were government escrow accounts.

Only now have the country's investigating agencies begun to fathom the extent of this new digital fraud. Rajesh Kumar, chief executive officer of the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C), reveals that Indian citizens lost Rs 120 crore to 'digital arrest' scams just in the first four months of the year; the losses from the entire range of cyber crimes—from 'digital arrests', sextortion, OTP scams to investment fraud—were a staggering Rs 1,776 crore. The masterminds of these scams are part of highly organised, transnational criminal syndicates based predominantly in Southeast Asia, including Cambodia, Laos, Thailand and Myanmar, making investigation difficult. The situation has escalated to such an extent that Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself brought it to national attention on his *Mann Ki Baat* radio programme on October 27, urging citizens to stay vigilant and not fall prey to such scams. "No government agency will ever contact you via phone or video call for such an investigation," he told the country's citizens.

Photo Montage by **BANDEEP SINGH**

WHAT IS DIGITAL ARREST

- Victims are contacted via phone calls, emails or messages, with scammers claiming they are under investigation for illegal activities such as identity theft or money-laundering
- Using threats of immediate arrest or legal action, the scammers isolate the victims, persuade them to join a video call and inform them they are "digitally arrested"
- Victims are then compelled to stay on the video call for hours or even days in an isolated environment
- The perpetrators coerce individuals into transferring large sums of money as a 'refundable security deposit' to specified bank accounts or UPI IDs under the pretence of "clearing their name" or "assisting with the investigation"
- However, there is no such thing as a digital arrest under law; all legal proceedings require in-person interaction under proper jurisdiction

NEW DELHI
RICHA MISHRA, 35
Journalist

The Con: **Fake parcel containing drugs; digital arrest**